

ABID BHAT

TAKING AIM
Paramilitary commandos at a security drill on the Dal lake in Srinagar

months, before the Valley's chinars reach their full autumnal bloom.

There had been straws in the wind. During a visit to Kashmir on May 16-17, Union home minister Amit Shah had already asked local party leaders to start preparing for assembly polls—last held in 2014—and even said the BJP would contest all seats in J&K. Modi, too, tapped into some of those themes on his visit, especially in an address to young achievers at the Sher-i-Kashmir International Conference Centre in Srinagar, on the banks of the Dal lake.

Hailing the large-scale participation in the Lok Sabha polls, he said: "What can be better than the people of J&K electing their representatives and tackling their problems through them. That is why preparations for the assembly election have started. The day is not far when you will select the new government of J&K.... The day will come soon when J&K will shape its future as a state once again." Entirely on cue, a day after Modi spoke, on June 22, the Election Commission of India announced the updating of electoral rolls in J&K and said the roll revision would be completed by August 20.

The usual complement of developmental projects, then, became part of the political outreach. Modi inaugurated projects worth over Rs 1,500 crore in road, water supply, infrastructure and higher education. He also launched the J&K Competitiveness Improvement in Agriculture and Allied Sectors Project worth Rs 1,800 crore, which will cover 1.5 million beneficiaries across 20 J&K districts. During his visit to Jammu in February, Modi had inaugurated projects worth Rs 3,200 crore.

THE RENEWED THREAT FROM TERRORISM IS A KEY CHALLENGE AS J&K MOVES TOWARDS ASSEMBLY POLLS

Modi's pronouncements have not fully enthused Kashmir's political parties, though. National Conference spokesperson Imran Nabi Dar says, "We have been hearing about 'conducting assembly elections soon'...we wonder what stops them from announcing the date." The return of statehood, according to him, is a commitment Shah made on the floor of Parliament and should not be reneged on. Political analyst Noor Ahmad Baba, too, says there is "nothing significant" in a fresh promise in the absence of a date. He cites the 'distance from Delhi' as a challenge for the BJP government which, he says, wanted to reshape Kashmir's political landscape but could not find the people's endorsement, as reflected in the general election results. "Right now, there is resentment not only in J&K but also in Ladakh and the government should start reconciliation for a better future," he says.

Also muddying the waters is the resurgence of an old scourge—Pakistan-sponsored terrorism. The south of the Pir Panjal mountains, a part of Jammu that had once been thought rid of the menace, has re-emerged as a hotbed

MADHYA PRADESH

The Grain Drain

By Rahul Noronha

A strange affliction seems to have gripped Madhya Pradesh this season. The country's largest producer of wheat after Uttar Pradesh and among its major wheat-buying states is seeing an inexplicable drop in procurement. Till June 25, the last day of procurement, the central Indian state had recorded the purchase of just over 4.8 million tonnes of the staple crop as against the nearly 7.1 MT it had collected in the previous rabi marketing season. What makes Madhya Pradesh



Mohan Yadav, CM

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